YEN Cuisine Japonaise

AI phone assistant — progress report and cost breakdown
Prepared 29 July 2026

Summary

The assistant answers the phone in French, understands English, and books real tables directly in your Libro account. It has been tested end to end and books correctly.

Running it costs roughly **$20 CAD per month**, against the **$275 CAD per month** currently being paid to the existing provider — a saving of about **$3,000 CAD per year**.

	Today	Proposed
Monthly running cost	~$275 CAD	**~$20 CAD**
Calls that reach a booking	15%	to be measured
Calls handed to a human	43%	to be measured
Takeout callers	transferred or told to use the website	handled — see page 3
Cancellations by phone	not possible	automatic
Who owns the call data	the provider	**you do**

The 15% and 43% figures are measured from 84 real calls to your line between 30 June and 25 July 2026, taken from the current provider's own records.

What is built and working

Capability	Status
Answers in French, switches to English if the caller does	Working
Checks live availability in Libro	Working
Creates, changes and cancels real reservations	Working — verified on a live booking
Reads the phone number back before booking; understands “demain soir”, “sept heures”, “vendredi prochain”	Working
Offers alternatives when the requested time is full	Working
Handles takeout callers (~1 call in 6)	Working — method under review, page 3
Answers hours, address, parking, dietary; never quotes prices	Working
Passes groups of 7+ to a person (Libro cannot hold those tables)	Working
Dashboard showing every call, outcome and transcript	Working
Answering a real phone number	**Next step** — needs the accounts below
Live transfer to a staff member	**Next** — details on page 3

Costs

All amounts in Canadian dollars. Converted from USD at 1.37, which should be confirmed against the rate on the day of payment.

One-time — development

Item	Detail	Cost
AI development tooling	Claude Max subscription, one month, including taxes — used to build the system	$160
Development time	Not charged	$0
One-time total		**$160**

A cost already incurred to build the system. It does not repeat. Development time is not being charged.

Recurring — monthly running cost

Service	What it does	Monthly
Server hosting	Runs the assistant, always on, in Toronto (Fly.io)	$9.80
Phone number	Montreal 514 number ($1.15/mo) plus inbound minutes (Twilio)	$2.90
Speech recognition	Understanding the caller, French and English (Deepgram)	$1.20
Voice	The French voice the caller hears (Cartesia, billed via LiveKit)	$1.80
Language model	Understanding what the caller wants (Google Gemini)	$1.50
Call records database	Stored in Canada; free at this volume (Supabase)	$0.00
Call handling	Connects the phone line; free at this volume (LiveKit)	$0.00
Subtotal		$17.20
Contingency (15%)	Rate changes, busier months, anything unforeseen	$2.60
Recurring total		**~$20 / month**

Based on your measured volume: 102 calls and 111 minutes per month. Most of the total is fixed cost, so it changes very little as calls increase.

Comparison

	Per month	Per year
Current provider	~$275	~$3,300
Proposed	~$20	~$240
Saving	**~$255**	**~$3,060**

Every account is in the restaurant's name and each provider bills you directly. No markup on any figure above.

What happens next

Two things are needed from you, and one decision.

1. Accounts to open

Each is opened in the restaurant's name, so you own it outright. Setup is about half a day in total; none need attention afterwards.

Account	Why	Card needed
Hosting (Fly.io)	Runs the assistant	Yes
Phone (Twilio)	The new 514 number	Yes
Google AI	Understanding callers	Yes — free tier is not reliable enough for a live line
Deepgram	Speech recognition and voice	Already open
LiveKit	Connects the phone line	Already open
Supabase	Call records, stored in Canada	No

2. A new phone number, not your existing one

The assistant answers a brand-new 514 number. Your existing line, 514-543-3354, is untouched and rings in the restaurant exactly as it does today. Nothing changes for your current callers until you decide to point them at it.

3. Escalation — confirming the details

Agreed and clear: **when the assistant cannot handle something, it transfers the caller to a person** during opening hours. Outside hours it gives them the email address instead. That is what will be built.

Two details to settle, because they change what gets built:

Question	Why it matters
If the transfer rings out, what then?	Take their name and number so you can call back, or simply let it ring? Either is fine — we just need to pick one.
Takeout — transfer, or take the details?	About one call in six. Transferring rings the restaurant during service; taking the details lets someone call back when it suits.

Timeline

Stage	What it involves
Now	Testing the conversation in every scenario
Next	Open the accounts above; connect the phone number
Then	You and I call the test number and listen to it work
Go live	Start with overflow only — it answers when nobody else can

On the figures: running costs are provider list prices applied to your measured call volume, and none has appeared on a real invoice yet — treat the first month as the number to confirm. The $275 comparison comes from your current provider's invoice.